

The dashing 53-year-old US ambassador to India, Timothy J. Roemer, exudes energy and optimism. The former US Congressman and basketball buff will need plenty of both if he has to successfully take on the challenging task thrust on him by President Barack Obama to be the 21st US envoy to India. His mission is difficult: To push Indo-US relations much beyond the nuclear deal and open new and exciting avenues of partnership. Just ahead of the Obama-Manmohan Singh summit on November 24, Roemer sat down with Managing Editor RAJ CHENGAPPA and Senior Editor SAURABH SHUKLA for an exclusive interview on the key issues on the agenda, including the remaining kinks in the nuclear deal. Excerpts:

Q. Post the nuclear deal, the Indo-US relationship seems to be drifting. Are there any new big hooks to hold bilateral ties?

A. We are moving from the civil nuclear deal to the five most important issues on the planet today. We are working to protect our people from terrorism. We are working together on education, on sharing technology on energy, agriculture and space and on how to build global economy in the 21st century. What's the new big idea? It is going to be the global partnership between the United States of America and India in the 21st century.

Q. There are still some problems on the nuclear deal, including reports that the US has asked India for some fresh assurances on the deal.

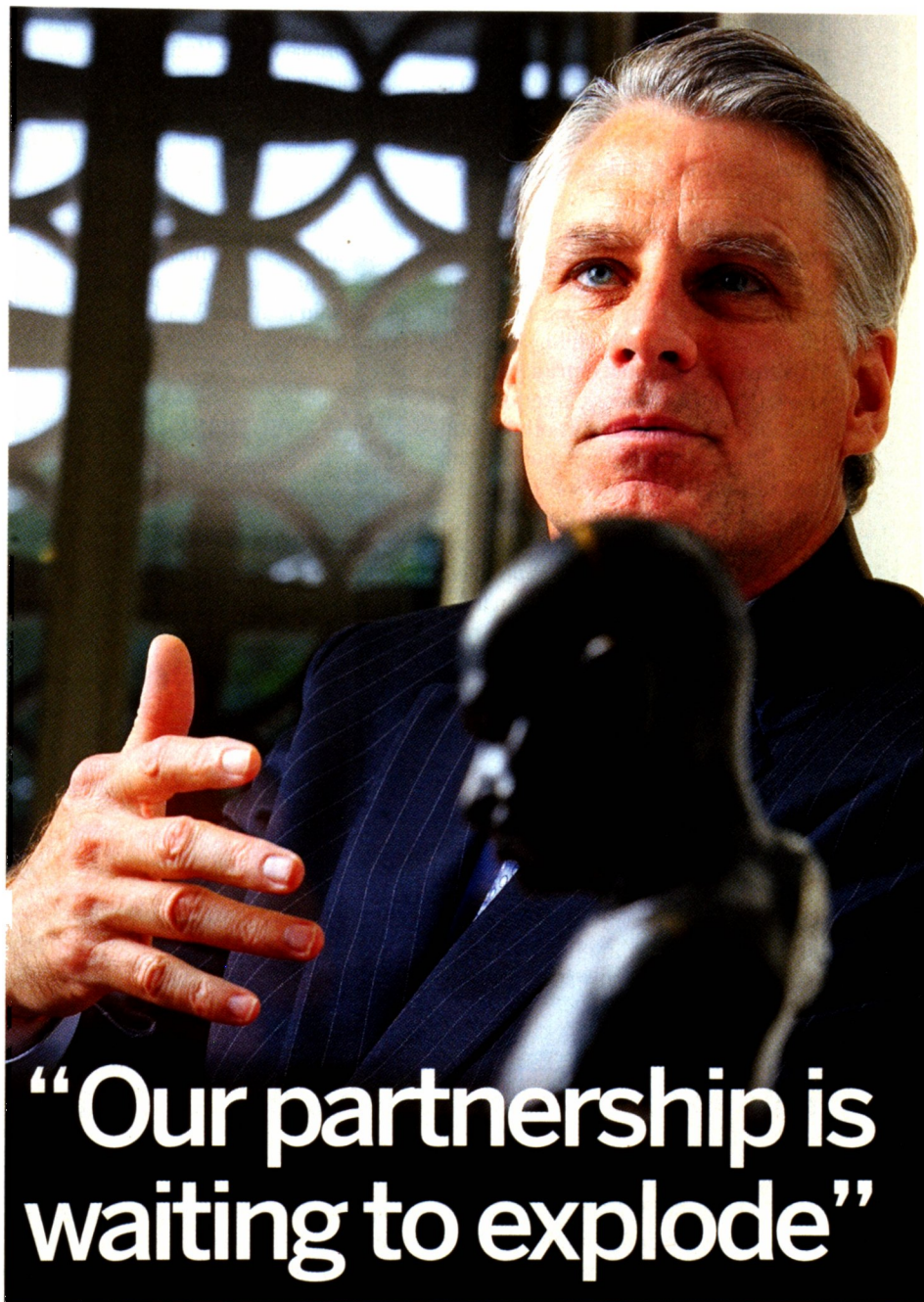
A. We can almost smell the finishing line. We are pleased that India announced the sites for nuclear power plants. The remaining issues are three-fold and we are pushing very hard to complete it. One is reprocessing negotiations. We are hopeful that both sides will show flexibility and will complete negotiations. Second, there is the issue of liability legislation that India has to take forward in its Parliament. The third issue is our licensing procedures, which the Indian Government has

known all along, something we require with all our allies. We have a one-page agreement that just assures us that you will use a certain technology from a US company that transfers it only for its intended purpose in the 123 Agreement. These are not new demands and there

are no surprises.

Q. But non-proliferation issues are back on the US agenda. Will that be a sticking point between the two countries?

A. There is a hope and a promise for the two countries to talk and show that they may work together towards a peaceful world without nuclear weapons. This doesn't mean that we will not have occasional differences.



“Our partnership is waiting to explode”

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